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Wheat markets are about to change in Virginia and Culpeper's Ardent Mills is leading the way. Their new investments in flour milling, for human consumption, has farmers talking about how to meet this new demand for local wheat.

Under construction today are new steel storage tanks and concrete silos rising into the skyline just east of town off route 3. They plan to have enough storage to warrant a 100-car unit train, carrying some 400,000 bushels and said to take up rail siding all the way to Mitchells. What this means for Virginia wheat growers is this. A new market is emerging here and demand for Virginia wheat will increase, if growers can meet milling standards. Expect to hear from Ardent on this topic.

Virginia grows soft red winter wheat traditionally and hard red wheat is being added. In 2016 we grew about 200,000 acres and harvested over 9 million bushels. A good acre will yield 50 bushels, a high yield is 100 and top farmers have yields reaching 122 bushels per acre in the 2017 yield contest. Ardent plans to add about 10% of our eastern wheat to their flour used primarily in pasta, cookies and biscuits. In the past, they only used hard red winter wheat grown in the west. We know now we can grow both wheat types in Virginia, but can we grow enough?

Milling quality wheat has historically been elusive. Millers require special traits in flour destined for human consumption. Qualifying for milling quality is worthwhile when seeing higher prices. Our climate challenges growers to "catch quality" before Mother Nature takes it away. Rainfall when wheat is mature damages quality, eroding test weight as one quality measure. Early harvest limits this weather exposure but increases grower cost. The trick will be for growers to "catch quality" to qualify for milling.

A positive outlook is for Ardent to increase wheat prices here in Culpeper. When compared to other wheat buying locations in Virginia, Culpeper should see higher price for wheat because of demand by Ardent. We can expect to see a higher price here when compared to our historic prices and when compared to prices in other locations because of their investments and activity.

The ripple effect of agriculture is significant and now we have more manufacturing to add to that. Ardent can take credit for several stimuli. Direct employment will be important to those who have jobs now or gain new jobs. The need for trucks and drivers to move more product away from the mill will go up. The increase in tax base alone could be the single largest benefit to our economy.

In sum, farmers can expect to be able to sell wheat they grow for higher prices if it meets milling quality. Wheat straw will become more abundant and this supports animal bedding needs and construction. Seed, fertilizer and chemical sales will follow along with farm equipment sales.



SMS Announcements

October 28, 2025



Clubs

- ~~Beta—This month's service project will be "Socktober". We are collecting warm socks, hats, gloves and blankets for a homeless shelter. FBLA is teaming up with Beta for this project.~~
- ~~Beta—those attending the convention will have short meetings during Tiger Time: 7th Grade on Wednesday and 6th Grade on Thursday. Mrs. Gay will be staying after school on Tuesdays and Thursdays until 4:30 for any Betas that want to stay and work on Beta Competitions.~~
- ~~FBLA—Any student who needs to work on their competition entries can stay after school on Wednesday, October 29th.~~

Sports

- ~~Soccer vs West Laurens October 28rd Away 4:30~~
- ~~Soccer vs Dublin October 30th Away 4:30~~
- ~~Wrestling, practice is today at SPS after school. You must have a physical on file to participate.~~

Media Center

- ~~If you owe a media center fine to SPS, SES, TCE or SMS, please pay your fines ASAP! You can pay any of these fines in the SMS Media Center.~~

Miscellaneous

- ~~Red Ribbon Week will be October 27th—October 31st. Dress days will be: Wednesday—"Detect the clue, choose drug free" (dress like a detective, spy, secret agent), Thursday—Pink Out Day: Help solve the puzzle of finding a cure" (wear pink for breast cancer awareness), and Friday—"Be the character who solves the puzzle" (dress as your favorite book, movie, or game character)~~

- ~~Another chance to win the spirit stick: Show up in full participation next week during Red Ribbon Week. The hall with the most participants WINS the spirit stick so bring your energy and Tiger Pride!~~
- ~~Yearbooks are on sale. You can order in the media center or online at the following link:
<https://link.entourageyearbooks.com/my/Swainsboromiddle26>.~~
- ~~Congratulations to the following students as they have been selected by their teachers as the student of the month for October: 6th Grade—Wyatt Bell, Aliana Brinson, and Mekhari Jordan, 8th Grade—Zoey Thompson, Community in Schools—Avia Phillips, Connections—Amiya Jones and Arabella Sheppard~~
- ~~Dress Code: Tops—Solid Gold, Black, White or Gray collared, polo, or oxford style or SMS Spirit Shirts (includes school affiliated athletics or student organizations), or Official Collegiate Shirts. Polo shirt dresses are not allowed. Hoodies or jackets must meet the same criteria as Polos, spirit shirts, or collegiate shirts. Bottoms—Skirts, shorts, and pants must be solid khaki, black or gray with no rips or tears and cannot be cut offs. Skirts and shorts cannot be shorter than 2 inches above the knee. No hoodies or hats are allowed to be worn in the building.~~

~~***The mission of SMS is to provide our students with meaningful learning experiences in a positive environment that prepares them for future success.~~

